

Zambia's Health and Economic Trend (1990 – 2023)

Summary Report

The focus of this summary is on life expectancy at birth, Gross Domestic Product (GDP) per capita, and health expenditure of Zambia. The dataset I used for the analysis were from the World Bank data: Life expectancy at birth, total (years), and the UN data: Nutrition and health - Health expenditure, and National Accounts - GDP and GDP per Capita. From this dataset, I analysed the data for the period 1990 to 2023 for life expectancy, 2005 to 2022 (2005, 2010, 2015, 2020, 2021, 2022) for Health expenditure (% of GDP) and 1995 to 2023 (1995, 2005, 2010, 2015, 2020, 2022, 2023) for GDP per Capita.

Insights

Life Expectancy at birth – indicates the number of years a newborn infant would live if prevailing patterns of mortality at the time of its birth were to stay the same throughout its life. From 1990 to 2023, the life expectancy at birth had the minimum of 46 years (1994 to 1999) to maximum of 66 years (2023).

GDP per Capita – is a key economic metric representing a country's total economic output (GDP) divided by its total population, essentially measuring average income per person. It is used to compare prosperity and living standards across nations. Between 2005 and 2010, the country's GDP per Capita rose from \$711.00 to \$1451.00, while life expectancy increased by 5 years (from 52 to 57). This shows that higher average incomes and improved living standards directly contributes to a longer life expectancy.

Health Expenditure – as a percentage of GDP measures the share of a country's total economic wealth channelled into healthcare goods and services annually. Health expenditure illustrates government commitment and investment appetite to healthcare financing. Despite a lower percentage of GDP spent on health in 2010 (4.00%) compared to 2005 (6.30%), higher total spending – driven by GDP growth – led to life expectancy rising from 52 to 57 years. This demonstrates that increased overall healthcare investment can improve population life expectancy.

Conclusion

There is a relationship between the economic growth and health investment, and longevity of a country. That is, as GDP per capita increases, life expectancy at birth increases, and as health expenditure increases, life expectancy at birth increases.

Limitations

The GDP Per capita and the Health Expenditure do not have data for every year compared to the life expectancy data.